

the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are aged 65 and over has increased by 1.5 million (1990–2000) and is projected to increase by a further 1.5 million by 2020 (Office of National Statistics 2000).

There is a growing awareness of the need to develop strategies to meet the needs of the ageing population. The Department of Health (2000) has identified the need to develop a 'new paradigm' of care for the ageing population. This paradigm is based on the concept of 'active ageing', which is defined as the process of optimising opportunities for health, participation in society and security in old age (World Health Organization 1999).

The Department of Health (2000) has identified a number of key areas for action in order to achieve this paradigm. These include: (1) promoting healthy lifestyles; (2) preventing illness and disability; (3) promoting social participation; (4) promoting security in old age; and (5) promoting the role of the voluntary sector. The Department of Health (2000) has also identified a number of key areas for research in order to achieve this paradigm. These include: (1) the role of the voluntary sector; (2) the role of the family; (3) the role of the community; and (4) the role of the state.

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